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Combinatorial Optimization

Volume 6 — Ad hoc algorithms

Ad hoc algorithms: the branch-and-bound on the critical item for the 0/1 knapsack problem and the DSATUR branch-and-bound for vertex coloring.

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Contents

38 Knapsack: branch-and-bound on the critical item **2**
38.1 The algorithm for the KP 3
38.2 A worked example 5
38.3 Typical mistakes 11
38.4 In summary 11

39 Vertex coloring: the DSATUR branch-and-bound **12**
39.1 The algorithm for the VCP 13
39.2 A worked example 17
39.3 Remarks 19
39.4 Typical mistakes 20
39.5 In summary 20

Chapter 38

Knapsack: branch-and-bound on the critical item

Prerequisites

- From the module *Integer linear programming*, Chapter 7 «Branch-and-bound»: branching and bounding operations, the problem list, the pruning criteria, the lower bound LB and the upper bound UB. The general algorithm is applied here to the 0/1 knapsack problem.
- From this module, the chapter «Formulations of knapsack problems»: the models ILP_{KP} and LP_{KP}, the efficiency of an item, the split item s, the residual capacity rc and the bound of Dantzig.

Objectives

At the end of this chapter you will be able to:

- write the problem LP^k_{KP} of a node, and solve it with the formulas of Dantzig, without the simplex algorithm;
- branch on the variable of the split item, unselecting or selecting that item;
- execute the branch-and-bound algorithm for the KP by hand, with the FIFO or the LIFO rule;
- explain why the algorithm is simpler than the general one, and what stays the same.

38.1 The algorithm for the KP

Definition 38.1: branching node and $\mathrm{LP}^k_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem

In the branch-and-bound algorithm for the $\mathrm{ILP}_{\mathrm{KP}}$ model, the branching constraints on a variable x_j, $j \in \mathscr{I}$, are $x_j \leq 0$ and $x_j \geq 1$. In a branching node k of the branch-and-bound tree, we have:

1. a subset of **unselected items** $\rightsquigarrow$ denoted $\mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{out}}$
2. a subset of **selected items** $\rightsquigarrow$ denoted $\mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{in}}$
3. a subset of **remaining items** $\rightsquigarrow$ denoted $\mathscr{I}^k := \mathscr{I} \setminus \left\{\mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{out}} \cup \mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{in}}\right\}$

The $\mathrm{LP}_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem associated to node k, called the $\mathrm{LP}^k_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem, reads as follows:

$$\begin{aligned}
\max \quad & \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}} p_j\, x_j \\
\text{subject to} \quad & \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}} w_j\, x_j \leq c, \\
& x_j \geq 1, && \forall j \in \mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{in}}, \\
& x_j \leq 0, && \forall j \in \mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{out}}, \\
& x_j \leq 1, && \forall j \in \mathscr{I}, \\
& x_j \geq 0, && \forall j \in \mathscr{I}.
\end{aligned}$$

- The branching constraints $x_j \leq 0$ and $x_j \geq 1$ have the effect of **unselecting** or **selecting** an item.

A $\mathrm{LP}^k_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem of a branching node k can be equivalently re-written as:

$$\underbrace{\sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{in}}} p_j}_{=p(k)} + \max \quad \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k} p_j\, x_j \tag{38.1a}$$

$$\text{subject to} \quad \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k} w_j\, x_j \leq \underbrace{c - \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{in}}} w_j}_{=c(k)}, \tag{38.1b}$$

$$x_j \leq 1, \qquad \forall j \in \mathscr{I}^k, \tag{38.1c}$$

$$x_j \geq 0, \qquad \forall j \in \mathscr{I}^k. \tag{38.1d}$$

- A $\mathrm{LP}^k_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem of a branching node k is **structurally equivalent** to the $\mathrm{LP}_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem but:

1. the set of items is $\mathscr{I}^k$ instead of $\mathscr{I}$
2. the capacity is reduced to $c(k) := c - \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k_{\text{in}}} w_j$
3. there is an objective-function constant $p(k) := \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k_{\text{in}}} p_j$

38.1.1 Solving the LP^k_{KP} problem of a node

- The problem LP^k_{KP} is a knapsack LP problem on the items of $\mathscr{I}^k$, with capacity $c(k)$: it is solved by the formulas of Dantzig, without any simplex iteration. The items of $\mathscr{I}^k$ are kept in the order of non-increasing efficiency.
- If $c(k) < 0$ the problem is **infeasible**. If $\sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k} w_j \leq c(k)$ all the items of $\mathscr{I}^k$ fit, and the optimal solution is $\tilde{x}_j = 1$ for all $j \in \mathscr{I}^k$: it is integer.
- Otherwise the **split item** s of the node is the first item of $\mathscr{I}^k$ that does not fit entirely, and the **residual capacity** is the capacity left by the items that precede it:

$$\sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k, j<s} w_j \leq c(k) < \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k, j \leq s} w_j, \qquad rc = c(k) - \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k, j<s} w_j.$$

- The optimal solution is $\tilde{x}_j = 1$ for the items of $\mathscr{I}^k$ before s, $\tilde{x}_s = \frac{rc}{w_s}$ and $\tilde{x}_j = 0$ for the items after s, and the optimal value is

$$z(\text{LP}^k_{\text{KP}}) \;=\; p(k) + \sum_{j \in \mathscr{I}^k, j<s} p_j + p_s \frac{rc}{w_s}.$$

In every node at most one variable is fractional, the one of the split item, and the value of the node is the Dantzig bound of a smaller knapsack: the node is solved by a scan of the items.

38.1.2 Branching-variable selection strategy

- The optimal solution of an LP^k_{KP} problem given by the formulas of the previous subsection has at most one fractional variable, the one associated to the split item. **Branching can be performed on the variable associated to the split item**: this branching-variable selection strategy is called split-item strategy.
- The optimal solution of an LP_{KP} problem is not unique when some items have equal efficiency: the other optimal solutions can have more fractional variables, for instance $x = (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$ for $p = (2, 2)$, $w = (2, 2)$, $c = 2$. Here, as in the general algorithm, we always use the solution given by the formulas.

38.1.3 What changes with respect to the general algorithm

- The algorithm is the LP-based branch-and-bound algorithm of the module *Integer linear programming* (Chapter 7 «Branch-and-bound»), with its problem list, its pruning criteria and its optimality gap.
- **Bounding.** The problem of a node is solved by the formulas above. All the profits are integer, so the bound of a node is $\lfloor z(\mathrm{LP}^k_{\mathrm{KP}}) \rfloor$: the node is pruned by bound if $\lfloor z(\mathrm{LP}^k_{\mathrm{KP}}) \rfloor \leq \mathrm{LB}$, by infeasibility if $c(k) < 0$, by integrality if its solution is integer (then LB is updated when the value is larger).
- **Branching.** The branching variable is the one of the split item s: the children are $x_s \leq 0$ (down, item unselected) and $x_s \geq 1$ (up, item selected), and the node is not solved with a simplex tableau but described by the sets $\mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{in}}$, $\mathscr{I}^k_{\mathrm{out}}$ and $\mathscr{I}^k$.
- **Node selection.** The node of the problem list is extracted with the FIFO or the LIFO rule, and the down-branching node is solved before the up-branching node; the nodes are numbered in the order of resolution. The lower bound written in a node is the value at the moment of its resolution.

38.2 A worked example

Example 38.1: The $\mathrm{ILP}_{\mathrm{KP}}$ model

We consider a knapsack of capacity $c = 9$ and a set $\mathscr{I} = \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$ of 6 items ($n = 6$), with the following profits and weights:

	$j=1$	$j=2$	$j=3$	$j=4$	$j=5$	$j=6$
p_j	6	5	8	9	6	7
w_j	2	3	6	7	5	9

We refer to this KP instance as Example 1. The $\mathrm{ILP}_{\mathrm{KP}}$ model for this KP instance is:

$$\begin{array}{rrrrrrrrrrrrrrr} \max & 6 & x_1 & +5 & x_2 & +8 & x_3 & +9 & x_4 & +6 & x_5 & +7 & x_6 & & \\ \text{subject to} & 2 & x_1 & +3 & x_2 & +6 & x_3 & +7 & x_4 & +5 & x_5 & +9 & x_6 & \leq & 9 \\ & & x_1, & & x_2, & & x_3, & & x_4, & & x_5, & & x_6 & \in & \{0,1\} \end{array}$$

An optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\mathrm{ILP}_{\mathrm{KP}})$ is:

$$\tilde{x}_1 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_2 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_3 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_4 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_5 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_6 = 0$$

The optimal value $z(\mathrm{ILP}_{\mathrm{KP}})$ is 15. The associated optimal solution of the KP is $\tilde{S} = \{1, 4\}$.

The items are sorted by non-increasing efficiency, since:

$$\frac{6}{2} \geq \frac{5}{3} \geq \frac{8}{6} \geq \frac{9}{7} \geq \frac{6}{5} \geq \frac{7}{9}$$

Example 38.2: Branch-and-bound algorithm for the ILP_{KP} model

A branch-and-bound algorithm for ILP_{KP} model and the KP instance of Example 1 using:

1. the split-item strategy as branching-variable selection strategy;
2. the FIFO rule as branching-node selection strategy;
3. solve first the down-branching node and then the up-branching node;
4. set the incumbent solution $\bar{\boldsymbol{x}}(\text{ILP}_{\text{KP}})$ to the following heuristic solution:

$$\bar{x}_1 = 1, \quad \bar{x}_2 = 0, \quad \bar{x}_3 = 0, \quad \bar{x}_4 = 1, \quad \bar{x}_5 = 0, \quad \bar{x}_6 = 0$$

and set the lower bound LB accordingly.

- **Initialization**

  For the LP^1_{KP} problem, the split item is $s = 3$ and the residual capacity is $rc = 4$. An optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\text{LP}^1_{\text{KP}})$ is:

$$\tilde{x}_1 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_2 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_3 = \frac{2}{3}, \quad \tilde{x}_4 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_5 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_6 = 0$$

  the optimal value is:

$$z(\text{LP}^1_{\text{KP}}) = 6 \cdot 1 + 5 \cdot 1 + 8 \cdot \frac{2}{3} = \frac{49}{3}$$

  The optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\text{LP}^1_{\text{KP}})$ is **fractional** and the LP^1_{KP} problem is **feasible**, so the LP^1_{KP} problem is inserted in the problem list L and the lower bound LB is set to 15 ($\text{LB}(\bar{\boldsymbol{x}}) = 15$).

  Due to the current lower bound LB and upper bound UB, we have:

$$15 \quad \leq \quad z(\text{ILP}_{\text{KP}}) \quad \leq \quad \underbrace{\left\lfloor \frac{49}{3} \right\rfloor}_{=16}$$

- **Iteration 1**

  The LP^1_{KP} problem is extracted and deleted from the problem list L.

  The branching variable is x_3. The LP^2_{KP} and LP^3_{KP} problems are created by unselecting ($x_3 \leq 0$) and selecting ($x_3 \geq 1$) item 3.

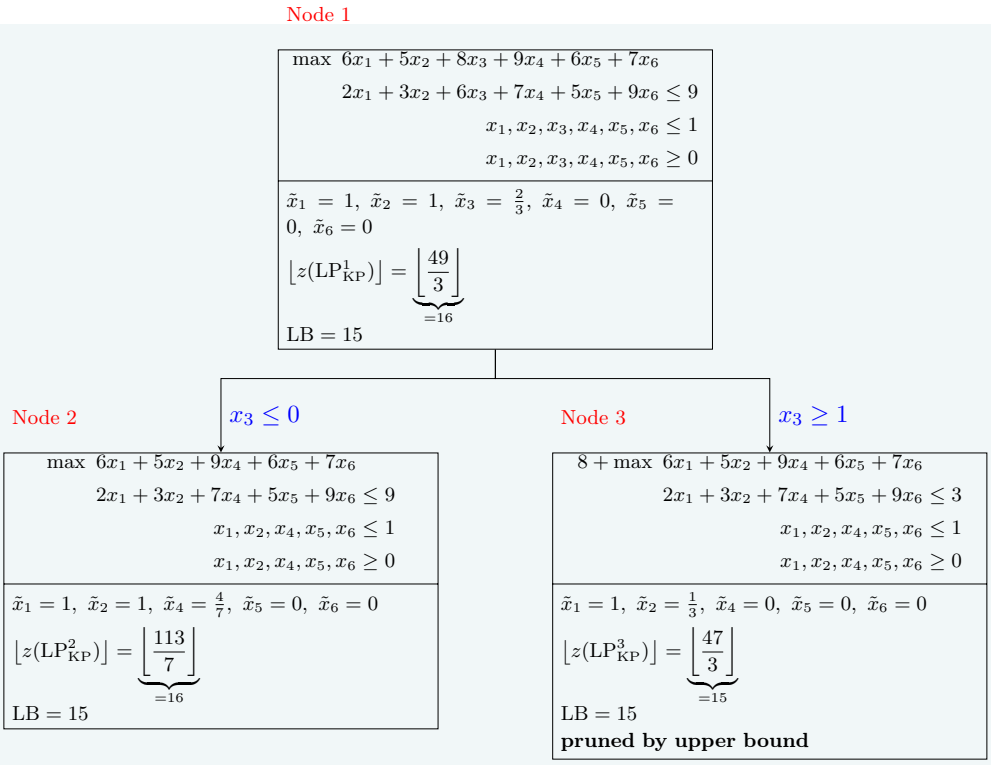
1. Solution of the $\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem

   We have
   $$\mathscr{I}^2 = \{1,2,4,5,6\}, \quad \mathscr{I}^2_{\mathrm{out}} = \{3\}, \quad \mathscr{I}^2_{\mathrm{in}} = \emptyset$$
   The capacity is $c(2) = 9$ and the objective-function constant is $p(2) = 0$. The split item is $s = 4$ and the residual capacity is $rc = 4$. An optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\,\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}\,)$ is:
   $$\tilde{x}_1 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_2 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_4 = \frac{4}{7}, \quad \tilde{x}_5 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_6 = 0$$
   and
   $$z(\,\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}\,) = 6 \cdot 1 + 5 \cdot 1 + 9 \cdot \frac{4}{7} = \frac{113}{7}$$
   The $\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem is **feasible** and we have:
   $$\lfloor z(\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}) \rfloor > \mathrm{LB} \qquad \text{since} \qquad \underbrace{\left\lfloor \frac{113}{7} \right\rfloor}_{=16} > 15$$
   The optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\,\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}\,)$ is **fractional**, accordingly, the $\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem is **inserted in the problem list** L.

2. Solution of the $\mathrm{LP}^3_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem

   We have
   $$\mathscr{I}^3 = \{1,2,4,5,6\}, \quad \mathscr{I}^3_{\mathrm{out}} = \emptyset, \quad \mathscr{I}^3_{\mathrm{in}} = \{3\}$$
   The capacity is $c(3) = 3$ and the objective-function constant is $p(3) = 8$. The split item is $s = 2$ and the residual capacity is $rc = 1$. An optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\,\mathrm{LP}^3_{\mathrm{KP}}\,)$ is:
   $$\tilde{x}_1 = 1, \ \tilde{x}_2 = \frac{1}{3}, \ \tilde{x}_4 = 0, \ \tilde{x}_5 = 0, \ \tilde{x}_6 = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad z(\,\mathrm{LP}^3_{\mathrm{KP}}\,) = 8{+}6{\cdot}1{+}5{\cdot}\frac{1}{3} = \frac{47}{3}$$
   The $\mathrm{LP}^3_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem is **feasible** and we have:
   $$\lfloor z(\mathrm{LP}^3_{\mathrm{KP}}) \rfloor \leq \mathrm{LB} \qquad \text{since} \qquad \underbrace{\left\lfloor \frac{47}{3} \right\rfloor}_{=15} \leq 15$$
   accordingly, the branching node is pruned by upper bound.

At the end of the first iteration, Node 2 is inserted in the problem list L, while Node 3 is pruned by upper bound. The corresponding branch-and-bound tree is:



Due to the current lower bound LB and upper bound UB, we have:

$$15 \quad \le \quad z(\mathrm{ILP}_{\mathrm{KP}}) \quad \le \quad \underbrace{\left\lfloor \frac{113}{7} \right\rfloor}_{=16}$$

- **Iteration 2**

The $\mathrm{LP}^2_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem is extracted and deleted from the problem list L.

The branching variable is x_4. The $\mathrm{LP}^4_{\mathrm{KP}}$ and $\mathrm{LP}^5_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problems are created by unselecting $(x_4 \le 0)$ and selecting $(x_4 \ge 1)$ item 4.

1. Solution of the $\mathrm{LP}^4_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem

   We have

   $$\mathscr{I}^4 = \{1,2,5,6\}, \quad \mathscr{I}^4_{\mathrm{out}} = \{3,4\}, \quad \mathscr{I}^4_{\mathrm{in}} = \emptyset$$

   The capacity is $c(4) = 9$ and the objective-function constant is $p(4) = 0$. The split item is $s = 5$ and the residual capacity is $rc = 4$. An optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\,\mathrm{LP}^4_{\mathrm{KP}}\,)$ is:

   $$\tilde{x}_1 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_2 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_5 = \frac{4}{5}, \quad \tilde{x}_6 = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad z(\,\mathrm{LP}^4_{\mathrm{KP}}\,) = 6\cdot 1 + 5\cdot 1 + 6\cdot\frac{4}{5} = \frac{79}{5}$$

The $\mathrm{LP}^4_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem is **feasible** and we have:

$$\lfloor z(\mathrm{LP}^4_{\mathrm{KP}}) \rfloor \leq \mathrm{LB} \qquad \text{since} \qquad \underbrace{\left\lfloor \frac{79}{5} \right\rfloor}_{=15} \leq 15$$

accordingly, the branching node is pruned by upper bound.

2. Solution of the $\mathrm{LP}^5_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem

We have

$$\mathscr{I}^5 = \{1, 2, 5, 6\}, \quad \mathscr{I}^5_{\mathrm{out}} = \{3\}, \quad \mathscr{I}^5_{\mathrm{in}} = \{4\}$$

The capacity is $c(5) = 2$ and the objective-function constant is $p(5) = 9$. The split item is $s = 2$ and the residual capacity is $rc = 0$. An optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\,\mathrm{LP}^5_{\mathrm{KP}}\,)$ is:

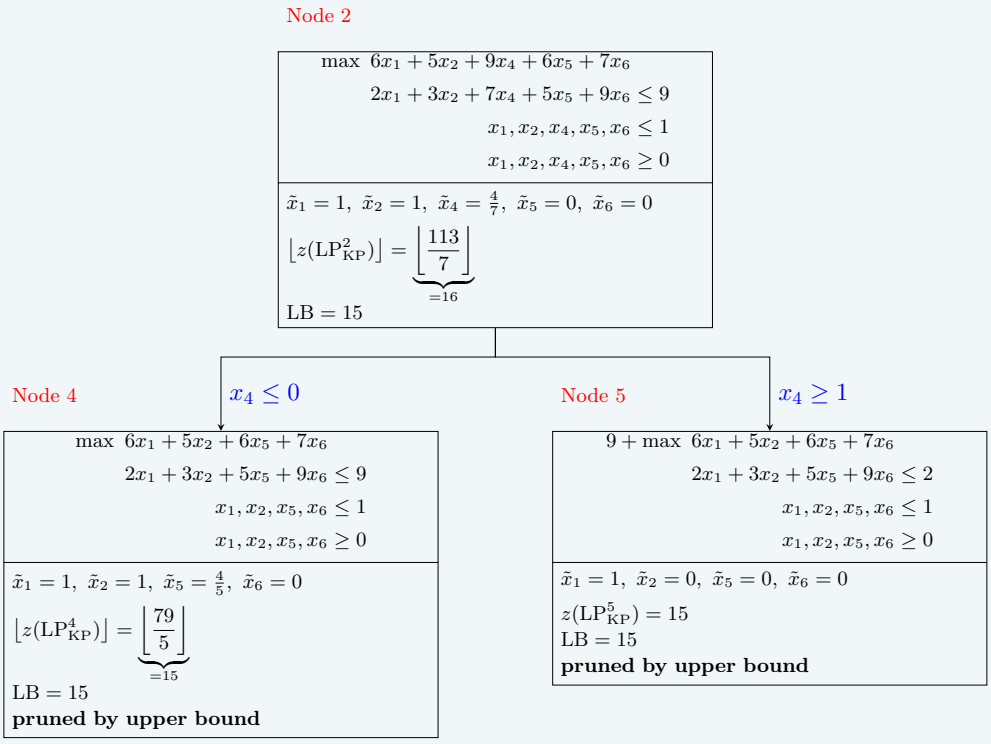
$$\tilde{x}_1 = 1, \quad \tilde{x}_2 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_5 = 0, \quad \tilde{x}_6 = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad z(\,\mathrm{LP}^5_{\mathrm{KP}}\,) = 9 + 6 \cdot 1 = 15$$

The $\mathrm{LP}^5_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem is **feasible** and we have:

$$\lfloor z(\mathrm{LP}^5_{\mathrm{KP}}) \rfloor \leq \mathrm{LB} \qquad \text{since} \qquad 15 \leq 15$$

accordingly, the branching node is pruned by upper bound. The optimal solution of the $\mathrm{LP}^5_{\mathrm{KP}}$ problem is also integer, but its value does not improve the incumbent solution: the node is pruned by bound, as the other nodes of this example.

At the end of the second iteration, Node 4 and Node 5 are both pruned by upper bound. The corresponding branch-and-bound tree is:

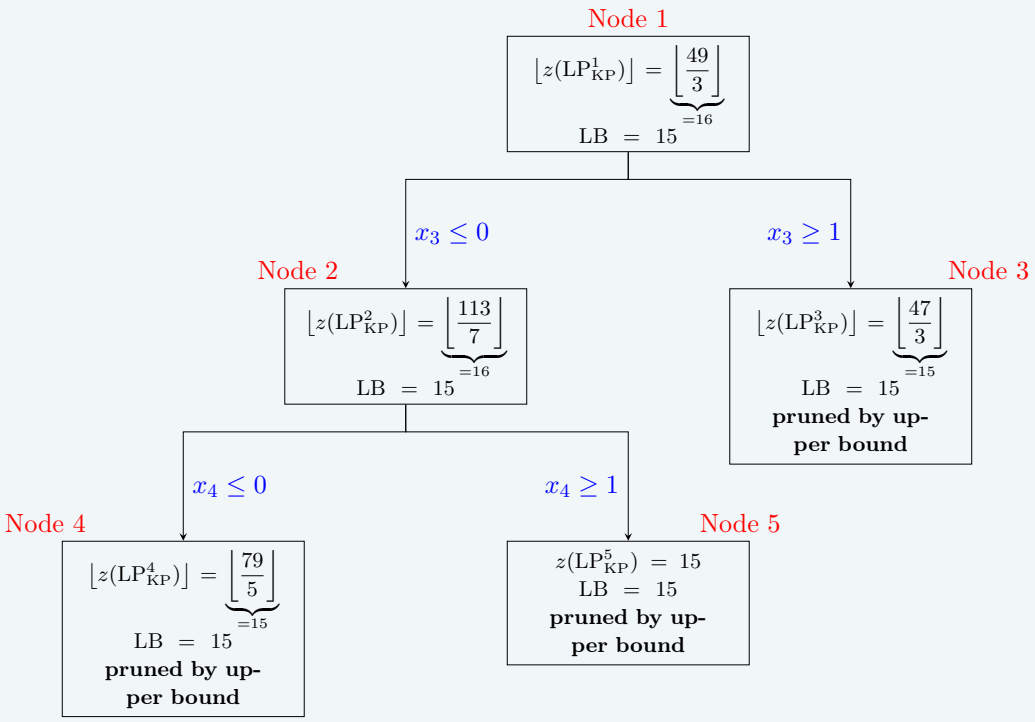


- **Termination**

  Since the problem list L is empty, the ILP_{KP} problem is solved to optimality.

  The optimal value is $z(\text{ILP}_{\text{KP}}) = 15$ (the value of the lower bound LB) and an optimal solution $\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}(\text{ILP}_{\text{KP}})$ is $\tilde{x}_1 = 1, \tilde{x}_2 = 0, \tilde{x}_3 = 0, \tilde{x}_4 = 1, \tilde{x}_5 = 0, \tilde{x}_6 = 0$ (the incumbent solution $\bar{\boldsymbol{x}}(ILP_{\text{KP}})$).

This is the branch-and-bound tree of the previous B&B Algorithm, showing for each branching node the associated LP_{KP} problem, its optimal solution and value, the lower bound LB, and the pruning criteria.



38.3 Typical mistakes

Warning

- **Forgetting the upper bounds $x_j \leq 1$.** Without them the LP problem of a node would put all the capacity on the item of best efficiency: the node boxes must contain $x_j \leq 1$.
- **Computing the split item on the original instance.** In a node, the split item and the residual capacity are computed on the items of $\mathscr{I}^k$ with the capacity $c(k)$, after fixing the items of $\mathscr{I}^k_{\text{in}}$ and $\mathscr{I}^k_{\text{out}}$.
- **Forgetting the constant $p(k)$.** The value of the node is $p(k)$ plus the value of the items of $\mathscr{I}^k$: the profit of the selected items counts.
- **Using the old lower bound.** The lower bound is updated as soon as a node has an integer solution of larger value; the nodes of the list that become dominated are discarded.
- **Numbering the skipped children.** A child that is not solved does not receive a node index, exactly as in the general algorithm.

38.4 In summary

Summary

- The branch-and-bound algorithm for the KP is the LP-based algorithm with two simplifications: the problem of every node is solved by the formulas of Dantzig, and the branching variable is the one of the split item.
- A node is described by the sets $\mathscr{I}^k_{\text{in}}$, $\mathscr{I}^k_{\text{out}}$ and $\mathscr{I}^k$, by the capacity $c(k)$ and by the constant $p(k)$.
- The bound of a node is $\lfloor z(\text{LP}^k_{\text{KP}}) \rfloor$; when the problem list is empty the lower and the upper bound coincide and the incumbent solution is optimal.

Dashboard of the KP instance of Example 1 ($c = 9$, $p = (6, 5, 8, 9, 6, 7)$, $w = (2, 3, 6, 7, 5, 9)$). The bounds on $z(\text{ILP}_{\text{KP}})$ found so far:

Source	Lower bound	Upper bound	From
Dantzig bound	–	16	$\lfloor \frac{49}{3} \rfloor$
This chapter, initialization	15	16	heuristic solution $\{1, 4\}$
This chapter, iteration 1	15	16	node 2 in the list, $\lfloor \frac{113}{7} \rfloor$
This chapter, termination	15	15	empty list, 5 nodes

Chapter 39

Vertex coloring: the DSATUR branch-and-bound

Prerequisites

- From the module *Integer linear programming*, Chapter 7 «Branch-and-bound»: branching and bounding operations, the problem list, the pruning criteria, the bounds LB and UB.
- From this module, Chapter 4 «Coloring problems»: the vertex coloring problem, cliques, stable sets and the clique bound $\omega(G) \leq \chi(G)$.
- From this module, Chapter 29 «Constructive heuristics»: the saturation degree and the $DSATUR$ heuristic.

Objectives

At the end of this chapter you will be able to:

- describe a node of the tree as a partial coloring, with its colors used and its saturation degrees;
- branch on the vertex of maximum saturation degree, with one child per feasible color and one new color;
- compute the upper bound with $DSATUR$, the lower bound with a greedy clique, and prune a node;
- execute the DSATUR branch-and-bound algorithm by hand and prove that it is exact.

39.1 The algorithm for the VCP

- The vertex coloring problem (VCP) on a graph $G = (V, E)$ is defined in Chapter 4 «Coloring problems»; its optimal value is the chromatic number $\chi(G)$.

Definition 39.1: branching node and partial coloring

In the DSATUR branch-and-bound algorithm, the colors are the integers $1, 2, 3, \ldots$, and a branching node k of the tree is a **partial coloring**:

1. a subset of **colored vertices** $\rightsquigarrow$ denoted $V^k \subseteq V$;
2. a color $col^k(v)$ for every $v \in V^k$, with $col^k(u) \neq col^k(v)$ for all $\{u, v\} \in E$, $u, v \in V^k$;
3. a subset of **uncolored vertices** $\rightsquigarrow$ denoted $U^k := V \setminus V^k$.

The colors used at node k are $1, 2, \ldots, q(k)$, where $q(k)$ is the **number of colors used**, and the color classes are $Q_c^k := \{ v \in V^k : col^k(v) = c \}$, $c = 1, \ldots, q(k)$. For an uncolored vertex $v \in U^k$:

$$sat_k(v) := \left|\{ col^k(u) : u \in N(v) \cap V^k \}\right| \quad \text{(\textbf{saturation degree})},$$

$$du_k(v) := |N(v) \cap U^k| \quad \text{(degree among the uncolored vertices)},$$

$$F_k(v) := \{ c \in \{1, \ldots, q(k)\} : Q_c^k \cap N(v) = \emptyset \} \quad \text{(\textbf{feasible colors})}.$$

- The saturation degree counts the *different* colors among the colored neighbours of v, and $|F_k(v)| = q(k) - sat_k(v)$.
- A node with $U^k = \emptyset$ is a **complete coloring**: a feasible solution of the VCP with $q(k)$ colors.

A node of the tree is a partial coloring; each child colors one more vertex. No LP problem is solved: the bounds of a node come from counting colors.

39.1.1 Branching

- **Branching vertex.** At node k we branch on the uncolored vertex v of **maximum saturation degree** $sat_k(v)$; ties are broken by the largest $du_k(v)$, and then by the smallest index. This is the rule of the *DSATUR* heuristic (Brélaz, 1979).
- **Children.** The children of node k give a color to v:
  1. one child for every feasible color $c \in F_k(v)$, in increasing order of c;
  2. one child with the **new color** $q(k) + 1$.
- The colors $q(k) + 2, q(k) + 3, \ldots$ are not used: a child with color $q(k) + 2$ would differ from the child with color $q(k) + 1$ only by the name of an empty color. The children are **no symmetric copies** of each other.
- The most saturated vertex has the fewest children: $|F_k(v)| + 1$. If $F_k(v) = \emptyset$, the node has only the child with the new color.

The branching vertex is the most constrained one; its children are its feasible colors plus one new color, so two children never describe the same coloring with the colors renamed.

39.1.2 Bounds and pruning

- The VCP is a minimization problem: the incumbent solution gives the **upper bound** UB, and a lower bound comes from a clique.
- **Upper bound.** Before branching, the $DSATUR$ heuristic of Chapter 29 «Constructive heuristics» gives the first incumbent solution, and UB is its number of colors.
- **Greedy clique.** The vertices are scanned by non-increasing degree (ties: smallest index), and a vertex enters K if it is adjacent to all the vertices already in K. The set $K = \{k_1, \dots, k_r\}$ is a maximal clique, and LB $:= r \le \omega(G) \le \chi(G)$.
- **Pre-coloring.** The vertices of K need r different colors in every coloring, and the names of the colors are arbitrary: the root node colors k_i with color i, $i = 1, \dots, r$. This breaks the symmetry of the first r colors.
- **Lower bound of a node.** The colors of a node are never removed in its subtree, so every complete coloring below node k uses at least $q(k)$ colors:

$$\text{LB}(k) \;:=\; \max\{\, q(k),\ |K| \,\} \;=\; q(k),$$

  where the equality holds because the clique is pre-colored.
- **Pruning.** The number of colors is an integer, so a node can lead to a better solution only if it uses fewer than UB colors. Node k is **pruned by bound** if

$$q(k) \;\ge\; \text{UB}.$$

- **Complete coloring.** A node with $U^k = \emptyset$ and $q(k) < \text{UB}$ is a new incumbent solution: UB $\leftarrow q(k)$, and the nodes of the list with $q \ge$ UB are removed. If UB $= |K|$, the incumbent solution is optimal and the algorithm stops.

$DSATUR$ gives UB, a greedy clique gives LB; a node is pruned as soon as it uses UB colors, because its subtree cannot contain a coloring with fewer colors.

39.1.3 Node selection and pseudocode

- The tree is explored **depth first**: the list L is a stack, the children of a node are evaluated in increasing order of color, and the child with the smallest color is extracted first.
- The nodes are numbered in the order of evaluation. A child is evaluated as soon as it is created: the evaluation only computes q and checks whether the coloring is complete.

Algorithm

Input: a VCP instance, i.e., a graph $G = (V, E)$.

Output: an optimal coloring and the chromatic number $\chi(G)$.

Step 0: **Initialization**

(a) Run $DSATUR$: set the incumbent solution to its coloring and UB to its number of colors.

(b) Find the greedy clique $K = \{k_1, \dots, k_r\}$ and set LB $\leftarrow r$. If LB = UB, the incumbent solution is optimal. `STOP`.

(c) Create node 1 with $col^1(k_i) = i$, $i = 1, \dots, r$, and $q(1) = r$. Insert node 1 into the list L and set the node counter $c \leftarrow 1$.

Step 1: **Optimality check**

If L is empty, UB is the optimal value and the incumbent solution is optimal. `STOP`.

Step 2: **Branching-node selection**

Remove from L the node k inserted last.

Step 3: **Branching**

Select $v \in U^k$ of maximum $sat_k(v)$, then maximum $du_k(v)$, then smallest index. For each color $c \in F_k(v) \cup \{q(k)+1\}$, in increasing order, create node $c+1$ as node k with $col(v) = c$, evaluate it with the **node sub-procedure**, and set $c \leftarrow c+1$. Insert the surviving children into L in decreasing order of color and go to Step 1.

- In Step 3, the counter c of the nodes and the color c of the child are two different numbers: the node created is the one with the next free index.
- This is the pseudocode of the **node sub-procedure**.

Algorithm

Input: a node h, i.e., a partial coloring with $q(h)$ colors.

Step 1: **Bounding operations**

(a) If $q(h) \geq$ UB, the node is pruned by bound. `STOP`.

(b) If $U^h = \emptyset$, update the upper bound and the incumbent solution: UB $\leftarrow q(h)$. Remove from L all the nodes with $q \geq$ UB. If UB = LB, the incumbent solution is optimal: `STOP` the algorithm. Otherwise `STOP`.

Step 2: **Survival**

The node survives: it is inserted into L in Step 3. `STOP`.

39.1.4 Correctness

Proposition 39.2: no-symmetry branching

Consider the tree of the DSATUR branch-and-bound algorithm without pruning. Its leaves are complete colorings, and every partition of V into stable sets, i.e., every feasible solution of the VCP, is the set of color classes of **exactly one** leaf.

Proof. Let $\mathcal{Q}$ be a partition of V into stable sets. The vertices of the clique K are pairwise adjacent, so they lie in r different classes; we give the name i to the class of k_i.

1. **Existence.** We follow a path from the root and keep this invariant: the classes of the node are the classes of $\mathcal{Q}$ restricted to V^k, each with its name. The root satisfies it. At node k, let v be the branching vertex and $Q \in \mathcal{Q}$ its class.
   - If Q already has a colored vertex, with name c, then no neighbour of v has color c, because Q is stable. Hence $c \in F_k(v)$, and the child with color c keeps the invariant.
   - Otherwise Q has no colored vertex yet: the child with the new color $q(k)+1$ keeps the invariant, and Q gets the name $q(k)+1$.

   Every step colors one vertex, so after $|U^1|$ steps we reach a leaf whose classes are $\mathcal{Q}$.

2. **Uniqueness.** Two different children of a node put v in different classes: with the colored vertices of two different colors, or with one of them and alone. The partition restricted to $V^k \cup \{v\}$ differs, so the leaves below two different children give different partitions. □

- **The algorithm is exact.** A node is pruned only if $q(k) \geq \mathrm{UB}$, and every leaf below it uses at least $q(k)$ colors: no coloring with fewer than UB colors is lost. When the list is empty, $\mathrm{UB} = \chi(G)$.
- Without the new-color rule, every partition with q classes would appear once for every way of naming its classes with the colors $1, \ldots, \mathrm{UB}-1$: the tree would contain many symmetric copies of the same solution.

Without pruning, the tree enumerates every feasible solution of the VCP exactly once, up to a renaming of the colors. The pruning by bound removes only subtrees with at least UB colors: the algorithm is exact.

39.2 A worked example

Example 39.1: DSATUR branch-and-bound on the Petersen graph

We consider the Petersen graph, the reference instance of Chapter 4 «Coloring problems», with $n = 10$ vertices, $m = 15$ edges and all degrees equal to 3:

$$E = \{\ \{1,2\},\ \{1,5\},\ \{1,6\},\ \{2,3\},\ \{2,7\},\ \{3,4\},\ \{3,8\},\ \{4,5\},\ \{4,9\},\ \{5,10\},\ \{6,8\},\ \{6,9\},\ \{7,9\},\ \{7,10\},\ \{8,10\}\ \}.$$

The DSATUR branch-and-bound algorithm uses the rules of Section 39.1: branching on the most saturated vertex, depth-first search, children in increasing order of color.

- **Initialization**

  1. The $DSATUR$ heuristic (Example «$DSATUR$ on the Petersen graph» of Chapter 29) colors the vertices in the order $1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 7, 9, 10$ and gives the incumbent solution

  $$\bar{\mathcal{Q}} = \{\ \{1,3,7\},\ \{2,4,6,10\},\ \{5,8,9\}\ \}, \qquad \text{UB} = 3.$$

  2. All the degrees are equal, so the greedy clique scans the vertices $1, 2, \ldots, 10$. Vertex 1 enters, vertex 2 is adjacent to 1 and enters, and no other vertex is adjacent to both. Hence $K = \{1, 2\}$ and $\text{LB} = 2$. The Petersen graph has no triangle, so $\omega(G) = 2$.
  3. Node 1 colors $col^1(1) = 1$ and $col^1(2) = 2$, with $q(1) = 2$. Since $\text{LB} = 2 < 3 = \text{UB}$, node 1 is inserted into the list L:

  $$2 \ \leq\ \chi(G)\ \leq\ 3.$$

- **Iteration 1**

  Node 1 is extracted from L. The vertices $3, 5, 6, 7$ have one colored neighbour each, so $sat_1 = 1$; the others have $sat_1 = 0$. The four tied vertices have $du_1 = 2$, so the smallest index wins: the branching vertex is 3. Its neighbour 2 has color 2, so $F_1(3) = \{1\}$.

  1. Node 2: $col(3) = 1$, with $q(2) = 2 < \text{UB}$. The node survives.
  2. Node 3: $col(3) = 3$, the new color, with $q(3) = 3 \geq \text{UB}$. The node is pruned by bound.

- **Iteration 2**

  Node 2 is extracted from L, with $Q_1 = \{1, 3\}$ and $Q_2 = \{2\}$. The vertices $4, 5, 6, 7, 8$ have $sat_2 = 1$ and $du_2 = 2$, and $9, 10$ have $sat_2 = 0$: the branching vertex is 4. Its neighbour 3 has color 1, so $F_2(4) = \{2\}$.

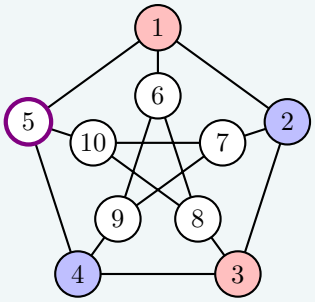
  1. Node 4: $col(4) = 2$, with $q(4) = 2 < \text{UB}$. The node survives.
  2. Node 5: $col(4) = 3$, with $q(5) = 3 \geq \text{UB}$. The node is pruned by bound.

- **Iteration 3**

  Node 4 is extracted from L, with $Q_1 = \{1, 3\}$ and $Q_2 = \{2, 4\}$. Vertex 5 has the neighbours 1 (color 1) and 4 (color 2): $sat_4(5) = 2$, the only vertex with saturation degree 2, so it is the branching vertex. Its feasible colors are $F_4(5) = \emptyset$.

  1. Node 6: $col(5) = 3$, the only child, with $q(6) = 3 \geq \text{UB}$. The node is pruned by bound.

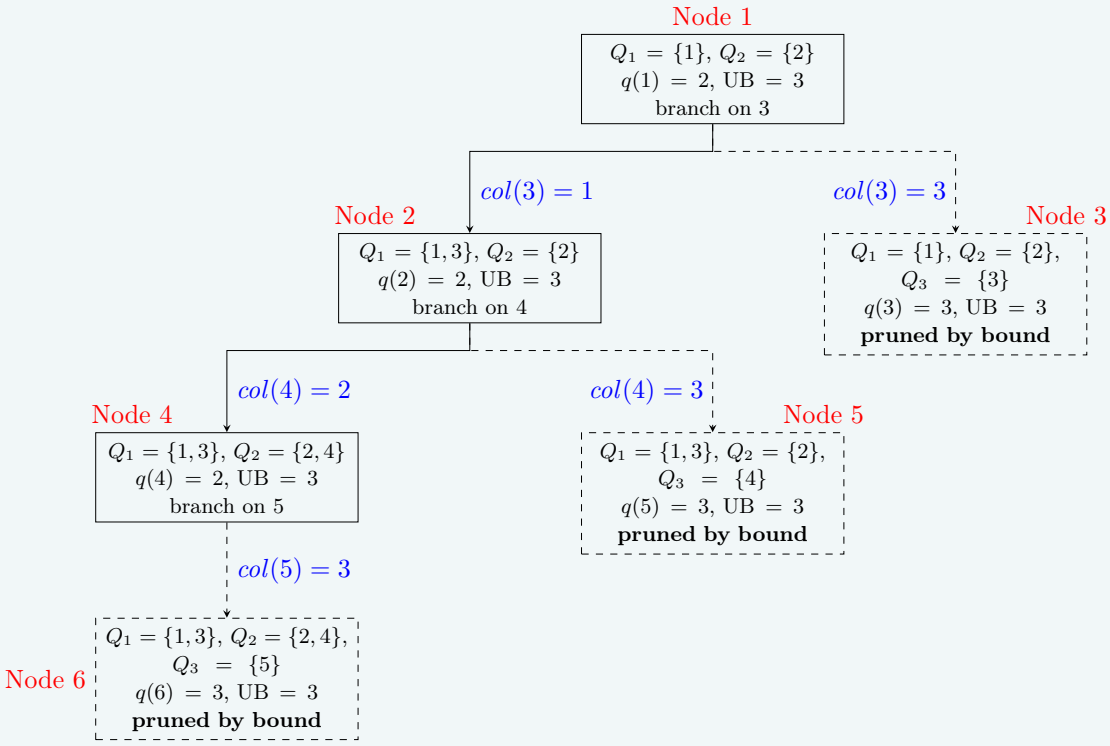
  The partial coloring of node 4 is drawn below: the cycle $1, 2, 3, 4, 5$ has five vertices, and two colors are not enough to close it.



- **Termination**

  The list L is empty: the incumbent solution $\bar{Q}$ is optimal and $\chi(G) = \text{UB} = 3$. The tree has 6 nodes.

This is the branch-and-bound tree, showing for each node its color classes, the number of colors q, the upper bound UB at the moment of the evaluation, and the branching vertex or the pruning criterion. The pruned nodes are dashed.



The nodes in the order of evaluation:

Node	Parent	Child	q	UB	Branching vertex	Outcome
1	–	root, $K = \{1, 2\}$	2	3	3 ($sat = 1$, $du = 2$)	branched
2	1	$col(3) = 1$	2	3	4 ($sat = 1$, $du = 2$)	branched
3	1	$col(3) = 3$	3	3	–	pruned by bound
4	2	$col(4) = 2$	2	3	5 ($sat = 2$, $du = 1$)	branched
5	2	$col(4) = 3$	3	3	–	pruned by bound
6	4	$col(5) = 3$	3	3	–	pruned by bound

- The algorithm does not improve the incumbent solution: it proves that UB $= 3$ is optimal. The proof is the odd cycle $1, 2, 3, 4, 5$, found by the search in three levels.
- Without the pruning, the tree of the Petersen graph has 9 776 nodes and 7 430 leaves, one for each feasible partition counted in Chapter 4, as Proposition 39.2 predicts.

39.3 Remarks

- **Origin.** The saturation degree and the exact algorithm that branches on it are due to Brélaz (1979). Pre-coloring a clique is the usual way to remove the symmetry of the first colors.
- **Sewell's tie-breaking (1996).** Among the vertices of maximum saturation degree, Sewell chooses the vertex v that maximizes the number of feasible colors it shares with its uncolored neighbours, $\sum_{u \in N(v) \cap U^k} |F_k(v) \cap F_k(u)|$. Coloring that vertex removes the most options from the rest of the graph.
- **PASS (San Segundo, 2012).** PASS applies Sewell's rule only to selected vertices, computing the count over the vertices tied for the maximum saturation degree, which is cheaper. Both rules change only the tie-breaking: the children, the bounds and Proposition 39.2 stay the same.
- References: D. Brélaz, «New methods to color the vertices of a graph», *Communications of the ACM* 22(4), 251–256, 1979; E. C. Sewell, «An improved algorithm for exact graph coloring», in D. S. Johnson, M. A. Trick (eds.), *Cliques, Coloring, and Satisfiability*, DIMACS Series in Discrete Mathematics and Theoretical Computer Science 26, 1996; P. San Segundo, «A new DSATUR-based algorithm for exact vertex coloring», *Computers & Operations Research* 39(7), 1724–1733, 2012.

39.4 Typical mistakes

Warning

- **Counting colored neighbours instead of colors.** The saturation degree counts the *different* colors around v: two neighbours with the same color count once.
- **One child per color $1, \dots, \text{UB} - 1$.** The unused colors are all equivalent: only the first new color $q(k) + 1$ gives a child, otherwise the tree contains symmetric copies of the same coloring.
- **Forgetting the new color.** The child with color $q(k) + 1$ is always created, even when $F_k(v) \neq \emptyset$; without it some colorings are never reached.
- **Pruning with $q(k) > \text{UB}$.** A node with $q(k) = \text{UB}$ cannot lead to a better coloring, because the number of colors is an integer: the rule is $q(k) \geq \text{UB}$.
- **Pre-coloring a set that is not a clique.** Only the vertices of a clique need pairwise different colors in every coloring; pre-coloring two non-adjacent vertices with different colors can cut off all the optimal colorings.
- **Continuing after $\text{UB} = |K|$.** When a complete coloring reaches the clique bound, it is optimal: the nodes still in the list are not explored.

39.5 In summary

Summary

- A node of the DSATUR branch-and-bound is a partial coloring; the algorithm branches on the most saturated vertex, with one child per feasible color and one new color.
- *DSATUR* gives the first upper bound, a greedy clique gives the lower bound and is pre-colored; a node is pruned when $q(k) \geq \text{UB}$.
- Without pruning the tree enumerates every feasible coloring once, up to a renaming of the colors: the algorithm is exact.

Dashboard of the Petersen graph ($n = 10$, $m = 15$). The bounds on $\chi(G)$ found so far:

Source	Lower bound	Upper bound	From
Clique bound (Chapter 4)	2	–	$\omega(G) = 2$
DSATUR (Chapter 29)	–	3	$\{1, 3, 7\}$, $\{2, 4, 6, 10\}$, $\{5, 8, 9\}$
This chapter, initialization	2	3	greedy clique $K = \{1, 2\}$
This chapter, termination	3	3	empty list, 6 nodes